Google's India Anchor

From an unexpected start in banking to leading Google India, Preeti Lobana's journey reflects a willingness to adapt

BY **PALAK AGARWAL**

WHEN PREETI LOBANA set out to pursue an MBA, a career in technology was hardly the plan. An arts graduate from Chandigarh, she was looking for a two-year course that would allow her to appear for the civil services examination at 21.



PHOTO BY **HARDIK CHHABRA**

Then someone told her about the Indian Institutes of Management. She landed at IIM Ahmedabad, and by the end of her first semester, her plans had changed.

"I made up my mind that I'm loving this and I want to go into the corporate world," recalls Lobana, now Vice-President and Country Manager of Google India.

That early willingness to change course became a defining feature of her career. The first person in her family to enter the corporate world, Lobana began in banking, working across companies such as Standard Chartered, American Express and NatWest. In January 2016, she joined Google. An India-focused role soon expanded into Asia-Pacific and then global responsibilities, giving her the opportunity to lead teams across geographies and cultures.

PREETI LOBANA
Vice-President and Country Manager, Google

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Walk the talk, be authentic and follow through with action. Always unlearn and relearn rather than rely on past successes

Yet, even as her career went global, Lobana chose to remain in India. Roles that were originally intended to be based in Tokyo or Hong Kong were accommodated from India, with travel and late-night calls part of the arrangement. Her conviction in India's potential, she says, has always been strong.

That belief now informs her role at a pivotal moment for the technology industry. But scale, in her view, means little without execution. "Announcements in the tech sector are very easy," she says.

Lobana makes a conscious effort to spend time with her family, immerse herself in nature, treks, and practise meditation. Mentoring women and young professionals is another priority. BT

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